AGRICULTURE
ALPHONSO

THE KING IN CRISIS

Maharashtra's famed mango faces one of its worst seasons, hitting yields and rural incomes in the Konkan region

By **DHAVAL S. KULKARNI** *in Malvan, Devgad, Ganpatipule (Maharashtra)*



MILIND SHELTE

Worry etched large across his face, Omkar Kulkarni points to a sprawling mango tree in his orchard in Nivendi village, near the pilgrimage centre of Ganpatipule in Maharashtra's Ratnagiri district. "This tree dates to my grandfather's time. Till recently, it would yield around 70 crates of Alphonso [popularly called Hapus]. This time, I will get barely 10," says Kulkarni. Around 200 km away in Malvan in neighbouring Sindhudurg district, farmer Sanjay Nare echoes Kulkarni's concern. In a normal year, he sells about 25,000 boxes of the prized fruit, each with a dozen; this season, he will be fortunate to reach even 5,000.

The Konkan coast, where the 'King of Fruits' is grown, is grappling with an unprecedented crop failure this year, leaving mango connoisseurs to contend with scarce Alphonso supplies and exorbitant prices—the mango is retailing in Mumbai at Rs 800-2,000 per dozen, compared to Rs 600-1,000 last year. "Alphonso production is expected to fall by 80 per cent of the Konkan's average of 250,000 tonnes," says Shivaji Amale, joint director, agriculture, Konkan division. The crisis has been driven by a mix of factors: erratic weather—delayed monsoon withdrawal, intense winter cold, with temperatures dipping below 10°C and disrupting pollinator activity, and wide day-night temperature variations—along with dew and mist that damaged the first flush of flowering; overuse of growth regulators, pesticides and fertilisers; and a decline in pollinators and cross-pollination.

In 2025, the Konkan had 129,427.22 hectares under mango plantations, with Ratnagiri and Sindhudurg at 68,550 and 34,598 hectares, respectively. The region produced 274,949 tonnes of mangoes, of which these two districts led with 184,602 and 38,058 tonnes, respectively. Notably, the Alphonsos grown in Ratnagiri and Sindhudurg are much sought-after for their thin skin and distinctive aroma and taste—a result of local climatic and geological conditions.

In Malvan, Nare says, the first flush of flowering around December was so intense that "it was impossible to see the leaves on mango trees". This led to expectations of a bumper crop. However, the flowering went to waste, with just a minuscule amount maturing into fruits due to the vagaries of the weather. Contract farmers like Nare, who take orchards on lease, stand to lose the most, as they need to pay the landowner in spite of any losses. Even a government compensa-